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AI & MACHINE LEARNING

Small open AI models now rival last year's best systems

Cheaper models that run on ordinary hardware put useful AI within reach of smaller teams, including in Pakistan.



An independent benchmark run by university researchers finds that open-weight language models small enough to run on a single laptop now match the scores that large closed systems posted a year ago. The test covered coding, maths and reading comprehension. Running the small models costs about a tenth as much, which could let schools, startups and local governments build their own tools. The researchers caution that benchmarks reward narrow skills and that small models still make more factual errors on open-ended questions. They also found wide gaps between languages: scores in Urdu and other South Asian languages trailed English by a large margin. The team has published its test set so that others can check the results and add new languages.

MIT Technology Review

Scan for the full story

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1 Running the small open models costs about a tenth as much as the large closed systems they now match.

2 The uncapped leg-spinner took the most wickets in this year's first-class competition.

3 Developers can enable cross-document view transitions with two lines of CSS.

PAKISTAN CRICKET

Pakistan pick an uncapped leg-spinner for the home Test series

Pakistan's selectors have named a 16-player squad for next month's two home Tests, calling up an uncapped leg-spinner after a strong domestic season.

ESPNcricinfo - Pakistan

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WEB DEVELOPMENT

Major browsers now support animated transitions between pages



"Simple multi-page sites can now feel as smooth as complex apps, with less code to maintain."

Every major browser now supports cross-document view transitions, a web standard that lets ordinary multi-page websites animate smoothly between pages. Developers opt in with two lines of CSS, and browsers that lack support simply load the next page as before. Early adopters report that shops and news sites feel faster, even though the pages themselves load no quicker.

Smashing Magazine
Scan for the full story

CYBERSECURITY

A widely used image library fixes a critical security flaw

Maintainers of a widely used open-source image library have released a fix for a critical flaw that let a specially crafted picture run code on any server that resizes uploaded images. The bug affects millions of websites that use the library behind the scenes. Security researchers urge developers to update now, because attack code is already circulating online.

BleepingComputer
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PAKISTAN TECH

Pakistan's IT exports grow as freelancers lead the rise

Pakistan's IT and IT-enabled services exports grew in the first quarter of the fiscal year, according to central bank figures, with freelancers and small software firms earning a bigger share than before. Industry groups credit faster payment channels for freelancers. They warn that slow internet speeds and frequent outages could hold back growth unless broadband capacity improves soon.

ProPakistani
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GADGETS & DEVICES

Budget phones get seven years of software updates in new industry pledge

Several large Android phone makers have agreed to provide at least seven years of security updates for new models, including budget phones.

GSMArena news & reviews
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SPORTS

INTERNATIONAL CRICKET

A darker pink ball is approved for day-night Tests



"Ball visibility at dusk has shaped results in day-night Tests, so the change could alter how teams plan."

A darker pink ball will be used in day-night Test matches from next season, after a year of trials in domestic cricket. Batters had complained that the old ball was hard to pick up at dusk, when light fades fastest. The new ball also kept its shape and colour longer in the trials, which bowlers hope will bring back swing in the later overs.

BBC Sport - Cricket
Scan for the full story

T20 LEAGUES

T20 league teams can keep four players before the draft

Each franchise in Pakistan's top T20 league may keep only four players before next season's draft, down from eight, under new rules announced on Thursday. Organisers say the change will spread star players more evenly and make more matches competitive. Teams must name their retained players by the end of November, and the draft itself will be held in Lahore in December.

Geo News - Sports
Scan for the full story

IN BRIEF

CLIMATE & ENVIRONMENT

Satellite study maps Karachi's hottest streets, block by block

Researchers combined satellite readings with street sensors to map Karachi's heat block by block, finding dense areas with few trees run several degrees hotter.

Dawn - Pakistan · dawn.com

PAKISTAN ECONOMY

Remittances from overseas Pakistanis rise for a third month

Money sent home by Pakistanis working abroad rose for a third month in a row, helped by a steady rupee and more transfers through banks.

Business Recorder - latest · brecorder.com

SPACE & ASTRONOMY

Astronomers find water vapour around a nearby rocky planet

Astronomers have found signs of water vapour in the atmosphere of a rocky planet about 40 light-years away, a rare result for a world this small.

Space.com · space.com

WORLD & PAKISTAN

CITIES & SOCIETY

Islamabad adds 30 electric buses to its feeder routes



"Faster, cleaner feeder buses could shorten daily commutes for people living on the edge of the capital."

Islamabad will add 30 electric buses to the feeder routes that connect outer sectors and nearby towns to its metro line, city officials said. The buses are due by December and will run every 15 minutes at peak hours. Fares stay the same, and riders will be able to pay with the same card used on the metro.

Express Tribune - Pakistan
Scan for the full story

GLOBAL AFFAIRS

Ministers meet early to unblock climate adaptation funding

Environment ministers from about 50 countries are meeting this weekend ahead of next month's UN climate summit, hoping to settle a long dispute over adaptation funding. Poorer countries want a clear share of climate money set aside for sea walls, drought-resistant crops and early-warning systems. Richer countries favour counting private investment toward the goal, which poorer nations call too uncertain.

BBC News - World
Scan for the full story

IN BRIEF

STARTUPS & VENTURE

Lahore agritech startup raises $6 million for crop insurance

A Lahore startup that sells weather-based crop insurance through a phone app has raised $6 million to reach more small farmers in Punjab and Sindh.

TechJuice · techjuice.pk

PUBLIC HEALTH

Dengue cases climb in Rawalpindi and Islamabad after the monsoon

Hospitals in Rawalpindi and Islamabad are seeing more dengue patients as the post-monsoon peak arrives, and officials are urging residents to clear standing water.

Geo News - Pakistan · geo.tv

MARKETS

Stocks close higher as banking shares extend gains

The Pakistan Stock Exchange closed higher on Friday as banking and energy shares extended their gains for a second session.

Business Recorder - Markets · brecorder.com

BEYOND YOUR USUAL

PUBLIC HEALTH

A nationwide polio drive aims to reach 40 million children

Covered by 9 outlets today

A week-long polio vaccination campaign starts on Monday across Pakistan, with health workers going door to door to reach more than 40 million children under five.

Dawn - Home · dawn.com

DESIGN & ARCHITECTURE

A mud-brick school in Sindh stays cool without air conditioning

Trying something new: Design & Architecture

A school built from mud bricks and lime in rural Sindh keeps classrooms several degrees cooler than concrete buildings nearby, without using air conditioning.

Dezeen · dezeen.com

FOOD & RECIPES

How to make winter pickles at home with three ingredients

Trying something new: Food & Recipes

Winter carrot and turnip pickles need only vegetables, salt and mustard seed, and a week in a warm spot, cooks say, making them an easy first ferment.

The Guardian - Food · theguardian.com

MUSIC

A young Lahore qawwali group sells out its first European tour

A step outside your usual

A qawwali ensemble whose members are all under 30 has sold out its first European tour, drawing audiences who had never heard the devotional music before.

The Guardian - Music · theguardian.com

WHY THESE STORIES

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THREE THINGS YOU LEARNED

1. Batters had complained that the old pink ball was hard to see at dusk.
2. Islamabad's 30 new electric feeder buses will run every 15 minutes at peak hours.
3. The flaw let a specially crafted picture run code on servers that resize uploaded images.

Tomorrow's Morning Recall will ask you about these.